

Taglish Chrome Style Guide — Galing Gear

Purpose: This guide governs how every string in the Taglish chrome catalogue (`src/lib/catalogues/taglish.ts`) is written. It exists to satisfy **safeguard 1** (§10.1 of the governing internationalisation standard): “The style guide is written first, not last.” A model or translator without a spec drifts batch to batch; three batches in, the only record of the sentence shape is the strings themselves.

Audience: The human reviewer (D-review-chrome), and any AI model used to produce initial Taglish drafts. Both must follow every rule below.

Scope: Track 1 site chrome only — nav, buttons, labels, headings, form messages, empty states, error messages, footer, page-level copy. Track 2 content (articles, rail-card body copy, image captions/alt) has its own generation prompt and is governed separately.

1. What Taglish is (and is not)

Taglish is **English-Tagalog code-switching** — the way educated Filipinos actually speak and text every day. It is not formal Tagalog, and it is not English with one Tagalog word sprinkled in.

The register we target is **casual-informed**: the voice of a trusted friend who happens to know a lot about emergency preparedness. Think neighbourhood kuya or ate who spent time abroad and came home — comfortable in both languages, switches naturally, never showboating in either.

It is explicitly NOT:

- Pure Tagalog (formal or colloquial)
 - Academic Filipino
 - Jejemon or heavy SMS-speak
 - English with a single Tagalog particle appended
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2. Register and tone

Dimension	Rule
Formality	Casual but competent. Emergency-preparedness content carries life-safety weight — never flippant, never bureaucratic.
Pronouns	Use “ka” / “mo” (2nd person singular, casual). Never “kayo” / “ninyo” (formal/plural) for a single reader — it reads like a government notice. Never “po” / “opo” — that is an honorific register the brand voice does not use.
Sentence structure	Let the code-switch happen at clause boundaries, not mid-word. A natural Taglish sentence often starts one language and finishes in the other — that is fine.
Sentence length	Match the English source length. Do not pad with filler words to sound more Filipino.
Contractions	Fine in both languages: “don’t”, “‘di” (for “hindi”), “‘yung” (for “iyong”).
Exclamation marks	One per string maximum. None in error messages.

3. Glossary — terms that stay English

These terms are **never translated**. They are either technical vocabulary the audience knows in English, or brand/product terms that must match across both locales.

3.1 Brand & product

Term	Reason
Galing Gear	Brand name
Subscribe / Unsubscribe	Product action — matches the button, the email, and the URL
Archive	Section name — matches the URL slug
Email	Universal; “e-liham” is not used in practice

3.2 Emergency preparedness & gear

Term	Reason
Gear	Central brand term; no single Tagalog equivalent covers the same range
Guide / Review	Article types; match the URL and the card labels
Scenario	Section name; “senaryo” exists but the site navigation uses the English
Brownout	Already borrowed into Philippine English and Tagalog
Typhoon	Standard meteorological term used across Philippine media
Flood / Earthquake	Standard terms; Tagalog equivalents (“baha”, “lindol”) are acceptable in flowing prose but the catalogue labels keep English for consistency with headings

3.3 UI / web

Term	Reason
Home	Navigation label
Error 404	Technical; universal
Dark theme / Light theme	UI convention

4. Glossary — terms that go Tagalog (or Taglish)

These terms **should** be in Tagalog/Taglish, not left in English, because the audience expects them and they read more naturally in the target register.

English source	Taglish equivalent	Notes
Read more / Read the review / Read the guide	“Basahin...” or “Tingnan...”	Natural call-to-action in Taglish
Join the list	“Sumali sa list” or “Mag-sign up”	Hybrid; “list” stays English
Back to home	“Bumalik sa home”	Hybrid
Nothing here yet	“Wala pang laman dito” or equivalent	Natural
Check back soon	“Balik ka ulit”	Casual
Your name	“Pangalan mo”	
Sending...	“Nagse-send...”	Taglish verb form (mag- prefix + English root)
Something went wrong	“May problema” or “Nagka-error”	
On this page	“Nasa page na ‘to”	Casual Taglish
Published / Updated	“Na-publish” / “Na-update”	Taglish verb forms
Our pick	“Pick namin” or “Top pick namin”	
Where to buy	“Saan bibilhin” or “Where to buy”	Either is natural; be consistent
Browse the archive	“Tingnan ang archive”	

§10.2 note: This glossary marks alignments where the same concept appears in multiple places (e.g. “Subscribe” in the nav, the form button, and the page heading). Those must use the same Tagalog/Taglish phrasing everywhere, or the inconsistency reads as unproofread. The reviewer must check cross-references.

5. Glossary — uncertain rows (questions for the reviewer)

Per §10.2: “Flag genuine questions as questions.” These are defensible either way; only a native ear can settle them.

Term	Option A	Option B	Question
“Editor’s pick”	“Editor’s pick” (keep English)	“Pick ng editor”	Does the English phrase feel natural enough in a Taglish context, or does it need localising?
“Also featured”	“Also featured”	“Featured din”	Same question — is the English already Taglish-natural here?
“Sponsored” / “Advertisement”	Keep English	“Bayad na ad” / “Ad”	Advertising terms — does the audience expect English or would Taglish feel more honest?
“Current” (article status)	“Current”	“Updated” / “Bago pa”	The English “Current” as a status badge — clear enough, or needs a Taglish equivalent?

6. Formatting rules

Rule	Detail
Placeholders	Preserve every <code>{placeholder}</code> exactly. Do not translate the placeholder name. Do not split a sentence around a placeholder — the whole sentence is one string.
Plurals	English plurals in the catalogue use <code>plural.article</code> / <code>plural.articles</code> etc. Tagalog does not inflect for number — if a Taglish string needs a plural noun, use <code>mga</code> + singular or keep the English plural as-is (both are natural in Taglish). The <code>plural.*</code> keys may map singular and plural to the same word if appropriate.
Numbers	Always use <code>{count}</code> , <code>{total}</code> etc. — never write out numbers in words.
Arrows	Preserve trailing <code>→</code> on call-to-action strings (e.g. <code>'Read more →'</code>).
Ellipsis	Use <code>...</code> (single character), not three dots.
Quotes	Use curly quotes (<code>' ' / " "</code>), not straight quotes.
British spelling	Any English that remains in a Taglish string keeps British spelling (colour, defence, organised). This is a brand-wide rule (ADR-007).
Em dash	Use <code>—</code> (em dash), not <code>--</code> or <code>-</code> .
No trailing full stop on labels/buttons	Buttons, nav items, and short labels do not end with a full stop. Longer prose strings (blurbs, descriptions) do.

7. Constraints — what a Taglish string must never do

1. **Never invent content.** The Taglish string expresses the same meaning as the English source. It does not add information, opinions, or claims that are not in the source.
2. **Never drop a placeholder.** Every `{name}` in the English source must appear in the Taglish string.
3. **Never translate brand names** (“Galing Gear”), product names, or URL-derived terms (“Archive”, “Scenario” as section names).

4. **Never use “po” / “opo” / “ho”.** The brand voice is casual-informed, not formal/honorific.
5. **Never use deep Tagalog** (literary/archaic vocabulary). If a term would send the reader to a dictionary, use the English word instead.
6. **Never mix registers within a single string.** If a string starts casual Taglish, it finishes casual Taglish — no sudden shift to formal Filipino or pure English mid-sentence.
7. **Never use text-speak** (jejemon, txtspk, random capitalisation).
8. **Preserve all HTML entities and special characters** (` ` ; `,` `\n` , etc.).

8. AI generation prompt guidance

When using an AI model to draft the Taglish catalogue, the prompt **must** include:

1. This entire style guide (or a faithful summary of it).
2. The locked glossary (§3–§4 above).
3. The uncertain rows (§5) flagged as questions, not settled answers.
4. The English source string and its key, so the model sees both the text and the namespace context.
5. An explicit instruction: “If you are unsure whether a term should be translated or kept in English, keep it in English. The reviewer will localise further if needed.”
6. The failure-mode warnings from §10.5:
 - Do not reach for a more formal register than the style guide allows.
 - Do not produce a sentence that is English with one Tagalog particle appended.
 - Keep affixes and verb conjugations consistent across strings (if “na-publish” is used for one past-tense verb, use “na-” for all past-tense verbs, not “in-” for some and “na-” for others).
 - Do not insert “po”, “opo”, or any honorific marker.

9. The gloss requirement (§10.3)

Every Taglish string in the catalogue **must** be accompanied by a back-translation gloss — a literal English rendering of what the Taglish actually says, not a copy of the English source.

Glosses are stored inline in `taglish.ts` as `_gloss.<key>` entries:

```
export const taglishCatalogue: Record<string, string> = {
  'nav.subscribe': 'Mag-subscribe',
  '_gloss.nav.subscribe': 'Subscribe (imperative)',

  'home.h1': 'Handa ka ba sa bagyo? Simulan sa tamang gear.',
  '_gloss.home.h1': 'Are you ready for the storm? Start with the right gear.',
}
```

- Glosses are **stripped at build time** (the catalogue loader filters `_gloss.*` and `_review.*` keys). They never ship to the reader.

- A gloss catches **meaning drift** but cannot catch “this sounds odd” — that is what the native reviewer is for.
- The source locale (English) never has glosses, and the loader rejects any that appear.

10. Review workflow

1. **AI drafts** the Taglish catalogue following this guide, including glosses.
2. **The reviewer** (named in `TAGLISH_REVIEW.reviewer` in `taglish.ts`) checks:
 - Tone and register: does it sound like the brand voice described in §2?
 - Glossary compliance: are §3 terms left in English? Are §4 terms in Taglish?
 - Uncertain rows (§5): settle each question.
 - Gloss accuracy: does each gloss faithfully describe what the Taglish string says?
 - Cross-reference alignment: do strings that express the same concept in different places use the same Taglish phrasing?
 - Placeholder completeness: every `{name}` present?
 - No constraint violations (§7).
3. **Once satisfied**, the reviewer writes their name and the date into `TAGLISH_REVIEW` in `taglish.ts`. This lifts the review gate and allows the Taglish catalogue to be served to readers.
4. **Subsequent edits** to the catalogue require re-review. The reviewer name/date should be updated to reflect the latest review pass.

11. Mechanically catchable checks

Per §10.5, these can be enforced by automated assertion:

Check	How
Every English key has a Taglish key	Compare key sets
No <code>_gloss.*</code> key without a matching translated key	Orphan check
No translated key without a <code>_gloss.*</code> key	Completeness check
No <code>po / opo / ho</code> on word boundaries	Regex <code>\b(po opo ho)\b</code> (case-insensitive) — test on a planted string first (§10.5 warning)
Placeholders preserved	Extract <code>{...}</code> from English, assert same set in Taglish
No straight quotes in Taglish strings	Regex <code>['"]</code> (excluding code/keys)
<code>_review.signed_off</code> present and non-null	Gate check

These can be added as a build-time or CI check when the catalogue is populated.

Last updated: 20 Sep 2026. Author: build agent. To be reviewed and amended by the native reviewer before the first Taglish catalogue is finalised.